Landfill

By Joyce Carol Oates

Scoot Campos, nineteen years old, a freshman engineering student at Michigan State University at Grand Rapids, has been reported missing by his dormitory room-mates in the late afternoon of Monday, March 27th. Last seen around 2 A.M. Saturday, March 25th, in the parking lot behind the Phi Epsilon fraternity house.

His roommates guessed something might be wrong, called the frat house, but there was no answer. Scoot's things were exactly as he'd left them sometime Saturday afternoon, and it wasn't like Scoot to stay over at the frat house on a Sunday night, or through Monday. He was only a pledge and didn't have a bed there, and he'd missed four Monday classes.

And now, in the early morning of April 17th, Mrs. Campos answers the phone on the first ring. These terrible weeks that her son has been missing, Mrs.

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Campos has answered the phone many times and made many calls, as her husband has made many calls, and now the call from the Tioga County Sheriff's Department they have been dreading. *Mrs. Campos? Are you seated? Is your husband there?*

Mrs. Campos is not seated but standing, barefoot, shivering, with matted hair and glazed eyes, her mouth tasting of scum from the hateful medication that has not yet helped her to sleep. Mr. Campos, hurriedly descending the stairs says, "Irene, what is it? Who is it?" and rudely pries her icy fingers off the receiver.

INTRODUCTION

Sometimes fiction is based on factual events. Such is the case with this selection based on a 2006 Missing Persons case in Trenton New Jersey . . . the facts are as follows:

John Fiocco, Jr. 19, was last seen in the early morning of March 25 after returning to his dormitory from an off-campus party. His roommate reported him missing to campus police about 36 hours later.

The following day, investigators found blood in and around the trash bin behind Fiocco's dorm. After a laboratory confirmed the blood was Fiocco's, investigators started

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sifting through a 1-acre, 20-foot deep area at the landfill, which authorities believe received the trash from Fiocco's dorm.

Is the fictionalization of such a tragic event morally ethical? Has the freedom of the press overstepped the bounds of good taste and appropriate consideration for the family and friends of John Fiocco, Jr? I'll leave that to you to decide. Landfill by Joyce Carol Oates.

Just the day before, in the car driving home, Mrs. Campos had dissolved into hysteria, screaming, "You don't have faith! You've given up faith, I hate you!" For it was crucial to believe, as Mrs. Campos believed, that, nearly three weeks after Hector, Jr., "disappeared," he might yet be found unharmed. He might yet call his anxious parents, after so many days of (inexplicably) not calling. He might show up to surprise his parents on Easter Sunday when they returned from St. Joseph's, might be in the kitchen, eating from the refrigerator.

Or maybe Hector had been injured and was amnesiac, or had been abducted but would escape his captor or be released. Or he had been wandering, drifting, who knew where, hitchhiking; he'd left the

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university without telling anyone, he was upset, had problems with a girl, a girl he'd never told his parents about, just as he'd never told them much about his personal life since sophomore year of high school. Maybe the Phi Epsilons had been putting pressure on Hector; maybe he'd been made to feel inferior among the pledges. He'd once called his mother to say how crappy he felt, never having enough money—the other guys had money, but *he* didn't. He'd told her that if the fraternity dropped him, didn't initiate him with the other pledges, he'd kill himself, he would. He swore he'd kill himself! And Mrs. Campos had pleaded, "Please don't say such terrible things! You don't mean what you're saying, you're breaking my heart."

It was no wonder that Hector had been so lonely, away from home for the first time in his life. None of his Southfield High friends were at Grand Rapids. His classes were too large; his professors scarcely knew him. Twelve thousand undergraduates at Grand Rapids. Three hundred residents in Brest Hall, an ugly high-rise where poor Hector shared a room with two other guys—Reb

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and Steve—who, in Hector's words, never went "out of their way" to be friendly to him.

In turn, Hector's roommates spoke vaguely of him when they were interviewed by Tioga County sheriff's deputies. *Didn't know Scoot too well, he kind of kept to himself, kind of obsessed about things, like the wrestling team last fall. He didn't make it, but the coach encouraged him to try again, so he was hopeful. Fraternity rush was a crazed time for Scoot. He was really happy when he got a bid from the Phi Eps. He was so proud of his pledge pin, and he was looking forward to living in the frat house next year if his dad O.K.'d it. Phi Eps are known for their keg parties—they're kind of wild-party guys.*

Who would notice . . . A drunken pledge crawling head first into the chute of his own volition . . . One of the guys grabs his ankles to pull him back, and he's kicking and yelling and laughing. At least it sounds like laughter. *Hey, guys? Help me? Help me, guys?*

He's kicking like crazy, so whoever has hold of his ankles has to let go -- and then his thick, stocky body

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lurches down the trash chute. It sounds like a pig squealing, or a kid shooting down a slide in an amusement park. At the end of the pitch-black, stale-air chute there should be something soft to break his fall, except there isn't, and with the impact of a hundred and seventy-five pounds Scoot Campos strikes the edge of the trash bin and his forehead hits its sharp metal lip.

Immediately he's bleeding, dazed; his neck has been twisted, his spine, his legs are buckled weirdly beneath him. He's too dazed to be panicked, not knowing what has happened or where he is. Feebly, he pleads "Hey, guys? Help me?" amid a confusion of rich, ripe, rotting smells, something rancid. He's upside down trying to turn, to rotate his body, stunned and quivering like a mangled worm, trying to lift his head, to breathe, to open his mouth, a terrible throbbing pain in his neck, in his upper spine. Like a gasping fish he opens his mouth, but he can't make a sound, can't call for help. For sure the guys will check on Scoot, make their way downstairs shouting and laughing like hyenas. *Craziest thing, this drunk pledge, smashed out of his head, slid down the*

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trash chute. It's not the first time a drunken pledge or active at the Phi Ep house has slid down the trash chute into the Dumpster. Anyway, at some point there *was* the intention to check on the pledge in the Dumpster, but amid the party noise, the swarm of people—including heavily made-up high-school girls—and the pounding music there were too many distractions.

When interviewed by the Tioga County investigators, none of the guys could remember, exactly. *First we knew Scoot was missing, it's the dean calling. Nobody here knew he was missing. Must've gone back to his dorm and something happened there, or maybe he never went back. But whatever happened to him didn't happen here.*

No, of course not . . . .not given the Fraternity's history. For several years in the nineteen-nineties, Phi Epsilon fraternity was "suspended" from the university for having violated a number of campus and city ordinances: underage/illegal drinking on the premises, keg parties in the front yard, "operating a public nuisance," sexual assaults against young women and high-

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school-age girls, and even, during a secret initiation ceremony in 1995, against a Phi Epsilon pledge who had to be rushed to a local emergency room with "rectal hemorrhaging." Bankrupt from fines, lawsuits, and a dwindling membership, the fraternity had gone off campus until, in 1999, a group of aggressive alums, led by a Michigan state legislator, campaigned to have it reinstated. Still, by 2006 the fraternity hadn't yet regained its pre-suspension numbers—it had only twenty-six active members, one-third of whom were on academic probation.

Tioga County landfill is where Hector, Jr., is found. Or his "remains"—battered and badly decomposed, his mouth filled with trash. He couldn't have protested if he'd been alive, buried, as he was, in rubble and raw garbage. Overhead are shrieking birds; in the vast landfill, dump trucks and bulldozers and a search team from the Tioga County Sheriff's Department in protective uniforms. Most of his teeth are broken at the roots, but those which remain are

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sufficient to identify Hector Campos, Jr., of Southfield, Michigan.

The police investigation has yet to determine whether Hector died in the early hours of March 25th in the steep-sided Dumpster behind the Phi Epsilon frat house—where investigators found stains and swaths of blood, as if made by wildly thrashing bloody wings—or whether he died as many as forty-eight hours later, after lying unconscious, possibly comatose from brain injuries, until Monday morning, and then being hauled away unseen beneath mounds of trash, cans, bottles, Styrofoam and cardboard packages, rancid raw garbage, stained and filthy clothing, and paper towels soaked in vomit. At approximately 6:45 A.M. on March 27th, he was dumped into the rear of a thunderous Tioga County Sanitation Department truck and hauled sixteen miles north of the city to the Packard Road recycling transfer station, to be compacted and then hauled away again to the gouged, misshapen, ever-shifting landscape of the Tioga County landfill.

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Jesus! You have to hope that the poor kid died right away, smashed out of his mind, diving down the trash chute into the Dumpster and breaking his neck on contact. Only the police investigators can bring themselves to imagine that Hector Campos, Jr., may have been "compacted" while still alive.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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